Simple Business English

First Meeting With a Retail Buyer: Ask Great Questions & Win a Pilot Test

Situation: Carlos, a Key Account Manager for a regional bakery brand, arrives at the headquarters of a 60-store supermarket chain. He meets Miriam, the procurement director, whose stores do not currently stock his products.
Carlos — Key Account Manager at a regional bakery manufacturer · **Miriam** — Procurement Director at a regional supermarket chain

Transcript

Miriam: Hello Carlos, welcome to our head office. Come on in and make yourself comfortable.

Carlos: Hello Miriam. **It is a pleasure to meet you in person.** Thank you for inviting me.

Miriam: Did you find our building without any trouble? Parking can be tricky around here.

Carlos: Yes, your directions were very clear, thank you. I parked right across the street.

Miriam: How was your drive from the airport this morning?

Carlos: The highway traffic was a bit heavy near the bridge, but the weather is lovely today.

Miriam: The rain finally stopped yesterday afternoon, so driving around the city is much easier now.

Carlos: That is always good news when traveling for business. Sunshine makes every trip better.

Miriam: Please, take a seat right here. Would you like some hot coffee or cold water?

Carlos: A glass of still water would be great, thank you. It has been a long morning.

Miriam: Here you go. My assistant told me that you visited one of our stores downtown yesterday.

Carlos: Yes, I visited store number twelve on Market Street yesterday evening around seven.

Miriam: That is one of our flagship locations. What did you think of the store layout?

Carlos: It looked very modern, clean, and well organized. It was very easy for shoppers to navigate.

Miriam: Thank you. We renovated ten stores last month, and sales in those locations are growing nicely.

Carlos: Congratulations, that is a huge project for sixty stores across such a big territory.

Miriam: It takes a lot of work. So, Carlos, what brought you to our office today?

Carlos: My main goal today is to learn more about your business.

Miriam: That is refreshing to hear. Most suppliers just start with a twenty-minute presentation about themselves.

Carlos: I promise not to do that. I did not even bring presentation slides today.

Miriam: That sounds very promising. Give me thirty seconds on your company first, just as background.

Carlos: We are an independent regional bakery company with twenty years of experience in packaged snacks.

Miriam: Do you produce everything locally in this region, or do you import raw materials?

Carlos: Our factory and main distribution warehouse are just two hours away from your central hub.

Miriam: That is very convenient for deliveries. What is your current retail coverage across the country?

Carlos: We supply over three hundred supermarkets across four neighboring districts with regular weekly deliveries.

Miriam: Good to know. Now the floor is yours. What would you like to ask me?

Carlos: What are your biggest priorities for this category right now?

Miriam: For packaged snacks, we need steady turnover, good shelf rotation, and strong customer loyalty.

Carlos: Are customers actively looking for healthier options when they shop in your stores lately?

Miriam: Yes, whole grain and low sugar products are growing faster than traditional sweet bakery items.

Carlos: How is your current range performing in that specific healthy snack segment?

Miriam: The shopper demand is definitely there, but our overall category revenue remains completely flat.

Carlos: Why do you think revenue is not growing along with that strong customer demand?

Miriam: Because our existing suppliers simply cannot keep the shelves full when demand goes up.

Carlos: Could you tell me a bit more about that?

Miriam: Our primary snack partner misses delivery windows regularly, especially ahead of busy weekends.

Carlos: That sounds very frustrating for store managers and disappointing for regular shoppers.

Miriam: It creates empty shelves during our peak weekend shopping hours, which hurts our store reputation.

Carlos: How often does this issue happen?

Miriam: Almost every other week, especially on Thursdays and Fridays when stores place larger orders.

Carlos: Do they explain why these recurring delivery delays keep happening to your stores?

Miriam: They blame raw material shortages and transport driver issues constantly, but excuses do not help.

Carlos: What has been your experience with your current suppliers?

Miriam: When deliveries actually arrive on time, product quality is acceptable, though packaging is rather dated.

Carlos: So product quality is fine, but delivery reliability is clearly falling short.

Miriam: Exactly. An empty shelf earns zero revenue and drives our loyal shoppers to competitors.

Carlos: That is completely true, and it damages customer trust in your renovated stores as well.

Miriam: Have your retail clients ever experienced similar problems with your company's supply chain?

Carlos: We pride ourselves on our delivery reliability.

Miriam: That sounds nice, but every salesperson makes that exact same claim in this office.

Carlos: In the past two years, our order fulfillment rate stayed above ninety-eight percent every month.

Miriam: How do you manage to maintain such a high rate during peak seasonal demand?

Carlos: We keep a three-week safety stock of finished goods in our central warehouse at all times.

Miriam: And what happens if a delivery truck breaks down on a delivery day?

Carlos: We have backup logistics contracts with two regional transport partners to cover urgent routes.

Miriam: That gives some real peace of mind, I must admit. Logistics reliability is critical.

Carlos: Still, I know you already have an established list of suppliers for this snack category.

Miriam: Yes, our snack category currently has four active suppliers on our store shelves.

Carlos: Are you looking to replace someone soon, or just add fresh new options?

Miriam: We actively want to replace the supplier with the worst delivery record this quarter.

Carlos: Which specific products of theirs sell the best when they are actually available?

Miriam: Their oat cookies and honey granola bars sell quite well whenever they are in stock.

Carlos: We produce very similar items with cleaner ingredients, modern packaging, and longer shelf life.

Miriam: What price segment do your bakery and snack products target in retail stores?

Carlos: Mid-market, right where your core family shoppers spend the bulk of their weekly budget.

Miriam: What gross margin percentage can you typically offer our retail chain on these items?

Carlos: Typically, we offer retailers between twenty-eight and thirty-two percent depending on delivery terms.

Miriam: Thirty percent is our standard threshold for allocating prime shelf space in our stores.

Carlos: That fits very well with our standard commercial structure and volume pricing.

Miriam: However, listing a new brand across sixty stores immediately is a big operational risk for us.

Carlos: I completely understand your hesitation on doing an immediate full rollout across sixty stores.

Miriam: We cannot afford another delivery mistake in this key category during our renovation campaign.

Carlos: Would a small pilot test make sense for you?

Miriam: How small of a test are you thinking about, and for how long?

Carlos: We could test five top-performing stores for eight weeks with our three best products.

Miriam: Five stores in the central city district would show realistic demand and shopper interest.

Carlos: Which specific products would you want to test first in those five central locations?

Miriam: Probably three items: your honey granola bar, oat cookies, and fruit biscuits would fit well.

Carlos: That selection covers the main shopper habits very nicely and addresses the current supply gaps.

Miriam: What kind of promotional support do you usually provide to retailers during a pilot test?

Carlos: We can fund bright yellow discount price tags and weekend tasting sessions in all five stores.

Miriam: Tasting sessions work extremely well in our high-traffic flagship stores on Saturday mornings.

Carlos: We will also supply dedicated shelf trays to keep the boxes neat and facing forward.

Miriam: That helps store staff keep shelves looking full and tidy without extra labor.

Carlos: If sales hit our agreed targets after eight weeks, we can review a wider rollout.

Miriam: What sales volume do you consider successful for these three items during the pilot?

Carlos: Around twenty-five units per store per week would be a solid, realistic benchmark.

Miriam: That is a very realistic number for our central stores based on category traffic.

Carlos: I will prepare a tailored proposal based on our discussion.

Miriam: When can you send the commercial terms and pilot details for my review?

Carlos: I will send everything by Friday afternoon at three o'clock, with all specifications included.

Miriam: Excellent. I will review the figures with my category buyer on Monday morning.

Carlos: Shall we schedule a follow-up meeting in two weeks?

Miriam: Yes, Thursday the fifteenth at ten in the morning works well in my calendar.

Carlos: Perfect. I will include that meeting date and clear agenda points in my email recap.

Miriam: Thank you for coming today, Carlos. This was a very productive conversation for both sides.

Carlos: Thank you for your time and open feedback, Miriam. Have a wonderful rest of your day!

Key phrases from this episode

It is a pleasure to meet you in person.	polite greeting when meeting someone face-to-face for the first time — It is a pleasure to meet you in person after so many emails. — We spoke on the phone last week, but it is a pleasure to meet you in person.
My main goal today is to learn more about your business.	stating that your objective is understanding their situation, not selling immediately — My main goal today is to learn more about your business and your strategic plans. — Rather than pitch our catalog, my main goal today is to learn more about your business.
What are your biggest priorities for this category right now?	asking an open question to find the client's current business focus — Before we look at products, what are your biggest priorities for this category right now? — What are your biggest priorities for this category right now as you plan for next year?
Could you tell me a bit more about that?	inviting the client to explain an issue or detail more deeply — You mentioned inventory delays; could you tell me a bit more about that? — Could you tell me a bit more about that customer feedback you received?
How often does this issue happen?	checking the frequency and severity of a client's problem — How often does this issue happen during busy holiday periods? — To understand the scale of the delay, how often does this issue happen?
What has been your experience with your current suppliers?	politely asking about competitor performance and satisfaction levels — What has been your experience with your current suppliers regarding lead times? — What has been your experience with your current suppliers on return policies?
We pride ourselves on our delivery reliability.	highlighting consistent logistics performance as a core company strength — We pride ourselves on our delivery reliability and high customer retention. — As a local producer, we pride ourselves on our delivery reliability.
Would a small pilot test make sense for you?	suggesting a low-risk trial to reduce buyer hesitation — Rather than listing all SKUs, would a small pilot test make sense for you? — Would a small pilot test make sense for you in your top regional stores?

I will prepare a tailored proposal based on our discussion.	promising to send a customized commercial offer reflecting the client's specific points — I will prepare a tailored proposal based on our discussion and send it tomorrow. — Thank you for the data; I will prepare a tailored proposal based on our discussion.
Shall we schedule a follow-up meeting in two weeks?	proposing a specific date for the next negotiation step — Shall we schedule a follow-up meeting in two weeks to review the pilot numbers? — Shall we schedule a follow-up meeting in two weeks after your team tests the samples?

Common mistakes

✗ Not: ~~I will prepare a proposal based on what we discussed about.~~
✓ Better: **I will prepare a proposal based on what we discussed.**
We say 'discuss something', not 'discuss about something'.

✗ Not: ~~Could you tell me why are deliveries always late?~~
✓ Better: **Could you tell me why deliveries are always late?**
In indirect questions, use normal statement word order: subject before verb.

✗ Not: ~~Can we agree about a pilot in five stores?~~
✓ Better: **Can we agree on a pilot in five stores?**
Use 'agree on' when deciding on a mutual plan, proposal, or condition.

✗ Not: ~~Who is your actual supplier for this bakery category?~~
✓ Better: **Who is your current supplier for this bakery category?**
'Actual' means real, not existing at the present time ('current').

✗ Not: ~~We can meet again after two weeks to review the results.~~
✓ Better: **We can meet again in two weeks to review the results.**
Use 'in' to indicate a future time period counted from today.

Quiz

1. What was Carlos's main objective during this first meeting?
A) To sign a contract for all sixty stores immediately.
B) To understand the buyer's needs and agree on next steps.
C) To present a long slideshow about his company history.

2. What major operational problem did Miriam reveal about her current supplier?
A) Frequent delivery delays that leave store shelves empty on weekends.
B) Poor ingredient quality and customer complaints about taste.
C) Extremely high prices that exceed regional supermarket standards.

3. How did Carlos prove his company's logistical reliability?
A) By promising free replacement stock whenever trucks are late.
B) By citing a 98% fulfillment rate and safety stock.
C) By offering to manage store shelf stocking himself every morning.

4. What compromise did the parties agree on regarding store rollout?
A) An immediate rollout across thirty suburban supermarkets.
B) An eight-week pilot test across five top-performing central stores.
C) A one-month discount promotion in all sixty retail locations.

5. When did Carlos commit to sending his tailored proposal?

A) By Friday afternoon at three o'clock.

B) In two weeks during their next face-to-face meeting.

C) Next Monday morning after Miriam talks to her buyer.

Answers: 1-B 2-A 3-B 4-B 5-A

Dialogue voices are AI-generated. Every episode is built on a real, anonymized case from the host's 15+ years in FMCG and key account management.